coursera | MoMA

What Is Contemporary Art? ✕

Today's goal • 3/3 items

Module 1
Introduction to What Is Contemporary Art?

Module 2
Media from Television to the Internet

Module 3
Territories & Transit

Module 4
Materials & Making

Module 5
Agency

Visibility

- ✓ Introduction to Module 5
  Reading • 10 min
- ✓ Pope.L's New York crawls
  Reading • 10 min
- ✓ In New York City with Pope.L | Direct action
  Video • 4 min
- ✓ Two artists consider Catherine Opie, Dyke, 1993
  Video • 2 min
- ✓ Tania Bruguera on Untitled (Havana, 2000), 2000
  Video • 4 min
- ✓ Luis Camnitzer on Memorial, 2009
  Video • 2 min
- ✓ Yara Said on the Refugee Flag, 2016
  Reading • 10 min
- ✓ Firelei Báez on For Améthyste and Athénaïre (Exiled Muses Beyond Jean Luc Nancy's Canon), Anacaonas, 2018
  Reading • 10 min

Voice

- ✓ Who speaks?
  Reading • 10 min
- ✓ Nick Cave on Soundsuit, 2011
  Video • 2 min
- ✓ Lawrence Abu Hamdan, Conflicted Phonemes, 2012
  Reading • 10 min
- ✓ P Staff on Weed Killer, 2017
  Reading • 10 min

Action

- ✓ Taking action
  Reading • 10 min
- ✓ Lorraine O'Grady on Mlle Bourgeoise Noire, 1980–83/2009
  Video • 2 min
- ✓ Xiao Lu on Dialogue, 1989
  Video • 2 min
- ✓ Ralph Borland, Suited for Subversion (Prototype), 2002
  Video • 1 min
- ✓ Defining and blurring identities through performance
  Reading • 10 min

Review & Respond

- ✓ Memory Check
  Practice Assignment • Grade: 80%
- ✓ Reflect on Agency in Module 5
  Dialogue • 15 min
- ✓ Optional Readings & Resources
  Reading • 10 min

Module 6
Power

Exposing Power

- ✓ Introduction to Module 6
  Reading • 10 min
- ✓ Instructor Christian Rattemeyer on Mark Lombardi's diagrams of power
  Video • 6 min
- ✓ What do war and peace have to do with chandeliers and portraits?
  Reading • 10 min
- ✓ Deana Lawson on Nation, 2017
  Video • 2 min

Abuse of Power

- ✓ How do artists critique power?
  Reading • 10 min
- ✓ Two responses to abuse of power
  Reading • 10 min
- ✓ Wolfgang Tillmans on Sendeschluss / End of Broadcast I, 2014
  Video • 2 min

Sources of Power

- ✓ Power: sources and resources
  Reading • 10 min
- ○ **Outer space to inner earth**
  Reading • 10 min
- ○ Curator Paola Antonelli on Massoud Hassani's Mine Kafon wind-powered deminer, 2011
  Video • 1 min
- ○ Rania Ghosn on After Oil, 2016
  Video • 4 min

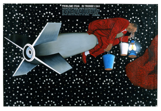
Review & Respond

- ○ Memory Check
  Practice Assignment
- ○ Reflecting on Power in Art
  Dialogue • 15 min
- ○ Final course reflection
  Graded Assignment • 30 min
- ○ Optional Readings & Resources
  Reading • 10 min
- ○ End-of-course survey
  Reading • 5 min
- ○ Recordings of live virtual sessions (optional)
  Reading • 10 min
- ○ MoMA Resources
  Reading • 10 min

Outer space to inner earth

0:05 / 5:20 1x

Chéri Samba, *Water Problem*, 2004


PROBLEME D'EAU . OU TROUVER L'EAU

Chéri Samba. *Water Problem*. 2004. Acrylic on canvas, 53 1/8 × 78 3/4" (135 × 200 cm). The Museum of Modern Art, New York. CAAC-The Pigozzi Collection. Gift of Jean Pigozzi. Courtesy Galerie MAGNIN-A, Paris

According to the United Nations Environment Program, the Democratic Republic of the Congo is Africa's most water-rich nation. Yet, in recent years, more than seventy percent of the country's population has faced an acute shortage of clean drinking water. Chéri Samba has long been focused on issues affecting Congolese society, and in his painting, *Water Problem*, he addresses this issue.

The artist represents himself on a rocket leaving Earth to look for water on Mars. In the text above, he writes the title of his painting in three languages (French, Lingala, and English) and goes on to narrate his quixotic quest: "Where to find water?…Concerned for his people suffering from dehydration, Chéri Samba goes looking for water on planet Mars, as if there wasn't any water left on Earth. Yes…it is necessary to spend million[s] of dollars to better serve his people in 100 years." By proposing an obviously unrealistic solution to the water problem, Samba underscores how urgently we must adjust our relationship with the environment and one of its most precious resources.

Lucy Raven, *China Town*, 2009

Lucy Raven. Still from *China Town*. 2009. Video (color, sound), 52 min. The Museum of Modern Art, New York. Purchase from the artist

Interested in the materials and infrastructure that underlie "wireless" technology, Lucy Raven traveled to a copper mine in Nevada. She photographed the miners and machines laboring to extract its ore, then journeyed with the valuable haul as it was trucked north to Vancouver and shipped west to a smelter in China. Raven characterized this process as "the American landscape being exported for reconstitution overseas." Across this span of place and time, she shows us how raw earth gets refined into spools of copper wire—a key component in conducting the electricity that powers modern life.

Raven's interest in form drove her experimental approach to documentation. She used animation techniques to stitch together the thousands of individual photographs into a film, creating a stuttering sequence of images set to the sounds she recorded along the way. No music, narration, or interviews supplement the film. We see and hear only what appeared before Raven's camera, which allows us, too, to feel like observers of the process.

Watch **an excerpt from *China Town*.**

Siv Helene Stangeland and Reinhard Kropf, Geopark, Stavanger, Norway, 2009

Siv Helene Stangeland, Reinhard Kropf. Architectural firm: Helen + Hard A. Geopark, Stavanger, Norway (Scale model, 1:200). 2009. Plexiglass, metal, sand, plastic, and card, 1 15/16 × 25 9/16 × 15 3/4" (5 × 65 × 40 cm). The Museum of Modern Art, New York. Gift of the architects and the Royal Norwegian Consulate General in New York

At Geopark, a public play area in the city of Stavanger, Norway's oil capital, excess materials from the local petroleum industry are transformed into objects of play. The park's form is based on the topography of a vast underwater natural gas and oil field, called Troll, with bright orange buoys, salvaged pipelines, and recycled drilling platforms forming bike ramps and interactive play spaces and a graffiti wall. To inform their design, the architects conducted workshops with community groups, in support of their idea that sustainable practices depend not only on materials and building methods but also on a supportive network of industry representatives and collaboration with citizens, including children.

View **photos of the park.**

Hito Steyerl, *Liquidity Inc.*, 2014

Hito Steyerl. *Liquidity Inc.*, 2014. Video (color, sound; 30 min.) and architectural environment. The Museum of Modern Art, New York. Gift of the artist. © 2019 Hito Steyerl. Installation view, *Surrounds: 11 Installations*, The Museum of Modern Art, New York, October 21, 2019–January 5, 2020. Digital Image © 2019 MoMA, NY. Photo: Denis Doorly

Water, money, mixed martial arts (MMA): they are all liquid in their own way, and they converge in Hito Steyerl's video-installation *Liquidity Inc.*, which interweaves the story of banker-turned-professional MMA fighter Jacob Wood with the powerful natural and human-made forces shaping our world. The 2008 financial crisis, which cost Wood his banking job, is among the work's main subjects. Rather than seek a way back into banking, he turned his MMA hobby into a career. "You don't want to be frozen…so you're always being liquid, and moving…," Wood says of fighting strategy.

Hito Steyerl. Still from *Liquidity Inc.* 2014. Video (color, sound; 30 min.) and architectural environment. The Museum of Modern Art, New York. Gift of the artist. © 2019 Hito Steyerl

Watch **an excerpt from *Liquidity Inc.***

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